

Tropical forest

Forests have flourished in the tropics for longer than they have existed anywhere else on earth, which helps to explain why the animal species that live there outnumber those of all other land habitats combined. Most large tropical forest animals have been identified and classified, but the invertebrate life is so diverse that the task of cataloguing it will never be complete. There are 2 main types of tropical forests: rain forest, which is closest to the equator; and seasonal, or monsoon, forest, which grows toward the edges of the tropical belt.

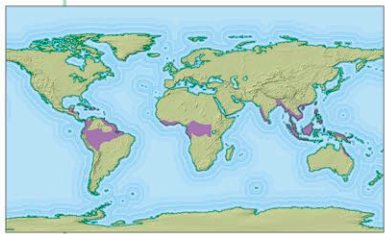
Tropical rain forest

Near the equator, the climate is warm and moist all year round, creating ideal conditions for plant growth. As a result, trees and other forest plants grow almost incessantly in an endless competition for light. Some plants put all their resources into growing towering trunks, while others are adapted for survival in partial shade. As a result of these different growth patterns, the forest is divided into clearly defined layers, each with its own characteristic animal species.

The highest layer, at about 245 ft (75 m), consists of giant, isolated trees called emergents. These provide nest sites for predatory birds and feeding platforms for monkeys. Beneath this level is the canopy, where copious light, combined with some protection provided by the emergents, results in a continuous layer of branches and lush foliage up to 65 ft (20 m) deep. This layer feeds or harbors most of the forest's animal life. Below the canopy is the understory—a more open layer made up of shade-tolerant trees. On the forest floor, leaf litter is food for

some very small animals as well as support for plants and saplings that grow where sufficient light filters through from above.

This zonal pattern is characteristic of lowland rain forest (the most common rain forest type). At higher altitudes, the trees are lower and the layers are more compressed—an effect that is exacerbated as altitude increases until eventually the trees form elfin forests little more than head high. Soil is also an important factor in shaping the forest. In some parts of the tropics, such as the Rio Negro region of South America, infertile sand results in the growth of stunted trees with leathery leaves.



TROPICAL RAIN FOREST is found near the equator, where annual rainfall exceeds 81¼ ft (2.5 m) and is spread throughout the year.



FOREST EAGLES have broad wings that enable them to glide through the canopy in their search for prey.



SLOTHS spend most of their lives suspended from branches in the forest canopy, relying on camouflage to avoid attack.



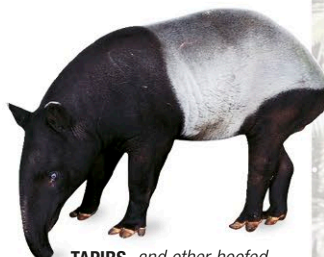
TROPICAL RAIN FOREST harbors a greater variety of tree frogs than any other habitat.



HOWLER MONKEYS of South America's rain forest are among the few primates that survive on leaves.



LEAFCUTTER ANTS are found at all levels in rain forest, from the ground to the highest tree tops.



TAPIRS, and other hoofed mammals, gather fallen fruit from the tropical forest floor.

EMERGENTS

CANOPY

UNDERSTORY

FOREST FLOOR

